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MY POWAI

Volume No. 14 Issue No. 05 Mumbai January 2026

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Dear friends

Wishing you a very happy New Year and welcome to the January issue of My Powai.

January is that gentle pause between what was and what can be—a month that nudges us to reset, reflect, and realign. Keeping that thought at the heart of this issue, we begin with wellness. Nutritionist Nisha Singh shares simple, practical ways to rebalance and reset your plate in the new year, reminding us that good health is built through everyday choices, not drastic resolutions.

From mindful eating, we move to indulgent flavours. On our recipe page, author Sherry Bhatnagar travels down south to Andhra Pradesh, exploring the bold, fiery world of Andhra cuisine. It's a culinary journey packed with spice, character, and stories that celebrate food in its most honest form. For those who like to look ahead before stepping forward, astrologer Richa Pathak reads the skies and predicts what the stars have in store for January 2026, offering insights that add perspective to the month ahead.

Alongside these features, the issue brings you local news, school updates, and several other interesting articles that reflect the everyday life, voices, and vibrancy of Powai.

As we turn the first pages of a new year, we hope this issue keeps you informed, inspired, and connected to the neighbourhood you call home. Happy reading, and once again, a very happy New Year from all of us at My Powai.

Warm regards,
Mahesh Kutty
(Editor)

Team MY POWAI

MAHESH KUTTY	EDITOR
SONIA KOHLI	CO-OWNER & MANAGING PARTNER
ELSIE GABRIEL	ASSOC. EDITOR
GEETANJALI DHULEKAR	ASSOC. EDITOR

For enquiries call 98200 28993.

Email: mypowai@yahoo.in

Mkting Off: B 2072, Oberoi Garden Estate, Chandivali, Mumbai 400 072

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Powai pollution



D.P.K. Udas

The Powai picturous suburb of Mumbai was once upon a time picnic spots for schools. The day long picnic was fresh breath of air from hassle bustles of city which was on Southern side.

During those days even Sanatoriums were here for sick persons to recover. Buddhist Monastery was here and in peaceful surroundings prayers were chanted. The proximity to lakes ensured that there is greenery all around as water table was high. However, this all has changed now. The quality of air has gone down. There is Pollution all around and even Lake is polluted now.

You will be surprised to know that Air Quality Index (AQI) of Powai is highest in this area and more than Eastern and Western suburbs. We checked on 23/12 AQI of Powai. It was 172.

The AQI of neighboring localities was as follows: **West** : Vile Parle - 63; Chakala - 67 **East:** Ghatkopar - 70; Mulund - 61; Chambur - 70 **South**:Sion - 61; Sewree - 33

In fact, earlier Chembur was most polluted area in Mumbai due to presence of RCF fertilizer plant, BPCL refinery & Tata Power thermal plant. However, due to public perseverance they have controlled their emissions. Who will take corrective actions for polluting Industry and Bhattis in Powai.?

Pollution reduces as we move towards Navi Mumbai.
Panvel – (78) ; Mahape (81) , Ambernath (64). Powai AQI further increased as follows: 24/12 - 203 ; 25/12 - 209 ; 26/12 - 207.

The increase is due to drop in temperature.

When we checked past figures, Powai recorded highest AQI in January 2022 which was 271. February 2022 was 182.

Now the question is as to why Powai AQI is higher than its neighborhoods? What is that which adds to Powai Pollution?

The answer is as follows
● Rampant Construction ● Demolition of Old buildings ● Presence of the Batching plant. ● The mining activity, stone quarries, stone crushers. ● Polluting Industries emitting hazardous chemicals. ● Bhattis melting metal scrap ● Restaurants kitchens with the exhaust fans. ● Breaking mountain to make buildings ● Increased Vehicular population ● Movement of concrete mixers and dumpers. ● DG sets at IT parks and Data Centers



If you visit hospitals in Powai , the majority patients are having respiratory issues. The appointment of Pulmonologist is difficult and not available immediately.

The residents are suffering following ailments: ● Sore throat ● Infections in nose , ear & lungs ● Dry Cough
Those exposed to Pollution for long time are suffering from following chronic diseases ● COPD (Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease) ● Lung Capacity Reduction ● Scarring of Lung Tissues ● Shortness of breath (emphysema) ● Bronchitis ● Asthma ● heart disease

Another issue is that Pollution here is with fine particles that are having dia of 2.5 mm or less. They are dangerous due to microscopic nature.

What are Preventive actions which residents should take ?
A) At home
- Keep windows closed
- Run air purifiers
- Frequent mopping and dusting.
- Use of vacuum cleaners

B) When Outdoor
- Wear Mask
- Wear face screens
- Avoid strenuous activities like brisk walking , jogging, etc.
- Do not take deep breath in.
- Keep building surroundings clean.
- Do not allow anyone to burn garbage, etc.

While we have to take care of ourselves, we need to work as community to reduce polluting activities as listed above.

As otherwise quality of life will reduce and so also " Life Expectancy ".

(The author is long time resident of Powai. He takes up civic issues with the authorities. He has been instrumental in improving illumination in the area, zebra crossings , garbage removal etc.)



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Chandan Chittaranjan Sharma: A legacy that chose service over spotlight.



Chandan Chittaranjan Sharma

In Powai, names are remembered not for the banners they raised, but for the work that quietly stayed behind. Chandan Chittaranjan Sharma belongs firmly to that tradition where public life is not a phase, but a lifelong inheritance shaped by responsibility, humility, and action.

His story does not begin with him. It begins generations earlier, with Late Shri Chandrabhan Sharma, a freedom fighter who believed deeply that *Education was the truest path to progress*. His family followed his legacy and founded many educational institutions at Powai so that the people and their children can get access to the education from Primary to Technical. *At a time when Powai was still finding its identity, he provided homes to countless families.* He was one of *Foundation Partner of IIT Bombay* and famously signed off land for the establishment of IIT Bombay an act that would shape not just Powai, but India's intellectual future. That conviction that development must empower people became the family's moral compass.

The legacy continued through leaders like Late Shri Harishchandra Sharma (Ex-MP), Late Shri Gopal Sharma, and Shri Prashant Sharma, who built institutions such as Chandrabhan Sharma College and Gopal Sharma School. Parallelly, Late Shri Chittaranjan Sharma laid strong civic foundations by establishing *Powai English High School* and *Gyan Mandir Marathi Madhyamik Shala*, and by serving as a Municipal Councillor from 1985 to 1992. Public service, in this family, was never ornamental it was practical, grounded, and relentless.

Adi Shankaracharya Marg was named following the initiative of the Sharma Family. The family also donated land for a Gurudwara, the Ayyappa Temple, and several other community institutions in Powai, with the vision of building a culturally vibrant, socially inclusive, and education-rich society.

It was into this continuum that Chandan Sharma stepped, not as a torchbearer by name, but as a worker by choice. Between 1997 and 2017, he served four terms as a Corporator in the Municipal Corporation of Greater Mumbai, dedicating two decades to Powai's everyday battles. His wife, Smt. Charu Chandan Sharma, also served a term



contd from Page 04



(2007–2012), reflecting a shared commitment to civic duty that ran through their household.

Those years were transformative for Powai. Once dependent on wells and plagued by water scarcity, the area witnessed massive infrastructure upgrades under sustained public pressure and planning. *Large pipelines were laid, pumping stations inaugurated, and a 10-lakh-litre water tank constructed at Durga Devi Sharma Udyan to serve the hilly areas.* These were not headline moments, but life-changing ones.

Chandan Sharma's work extended beyond infrastructure. Under housing schemes like *Gharkul, public toilets* were built in slum areas with dignity in mind. Powai received its first free mortuary van. A 24×7 ambulance service was introduced. Annual blood donation camps became a constant, not an exception. During the 26 July 2005 floods, relief reached those stranded. During COVID-19, he along with his full team was on the ground coordinating sanitisation drives, distributing food, and standing with people when uncertainty was at its peak.

Equally telling were the quieter gestures: senior citizens' offices inaugurated, tree plantation drives led by elders themselves, decades-long Puri Bhaji distribution during Ganesh Visarjan, statues installed to honour culture and faith, and decisive campaigns like the one that led to the cleanup of Powai Lake when apathy threatened its survival.

What stands out is not just the volume of work, but the manner. Chandan Sharma has consistently worked across political lines, supported by leaders from different parties, guided by the belief that civic issues do not wear party colours. Corruption-free public service, accountability, and continuity have been his anchors.

Three decades in public life teach one important lesson that development is never complete, only ongoing. Chandan Sharma acknowledges this openly. Each generation faces new challenges, and solutions must evolve. Yet, values remain constant.

In a city that changes by the minute, Powai remembers those who stayed. And whenever Powai has needed him, Chandan Chittaranjan Sharma has been ready to serve not as a promise, but as a habit built over a lifetime.





New Year, New Shield:

Why individual home insurance matters even in a housing society

A new year often begins with quiet promises — to protect what matters, to be better prepared, and to bring more peace of mind into our lives. For most of us, our home sits at the centre of those promises. Yet, when it comes to protecting it, many homeowners believe, "Our housing society already has insurance. Isn't that enough?"

While housing society insurance is important, it is not complete protection for individual homeowners.

In India, society insurance typically covers the building's external structure and common areas — walls, lifts, parking, staircases, clubhouses and shared facilities. This ensures the society can rebuild or repair after a major event. However, what lies inside your flat — the space you have lovingly built — is largely outside its scope.

This is where individual flat or home insurance becomes essential.

Your personal policy protects what truly makes the house your home: your furniture, appliances, electronics, décor, and valuables. It also covers interior fixtures such as modular kitchens, wardrobes, flooring, and renovations — items often excluded from society policies.

There's also the aspect of personal liability. If a visitor slips inside your flat, or if a fire or water leakage from your unit damages a neighbour's home, the responsibility is personal. Individual home insurance provides a crucial financial shield against such unexpected legal or compensation claims.

Another overlooked benefit is alternative accommodation. If your flat becomes temporarily unliveable due to fire, flooding, or other insured events, many individual policies cover rental or hotel expenses — a comfort society insurance usually does not extend.

For homeowners with a housing loan, this protection becomes even more relevant. Most banks require individual property insurance, regardless of society coverage.

As you step into the new year, think of individual home insurance not as an extra cost, but as a quiet promise — to safeguard your space, your memories, and your peace of mind.

Because a well-protected home allows you to focus on what truly matters: living well.

- Uma Kumaravelan
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Champions always



"Real champions lead with efforts, not ego. The fight is always within first"

Once a champion, always a champion. Gopal Sharma International School won the Best School trophy in the EduConnectin Expo. It is one of the largest and the most impactful platform dedicated to schools, teachers, knowledge creators and school suppliers. The most significant highlight was of the Education Excellence Award, where distinguished principals from various institutions were felicitated for their commitment to academic advancement, student development and institutional leadership.



A moment of immense pride and honour as our school principal Dr Sunny Mathew received the 'Best School Award' with an excellent rating out of 9,205 schools in Mumbai. This recognition stands as a proud testament to the entire school's unwavering commitment to excellence in education, innovation in learning and holistic student development, reaffirming its place among the leading institutions of Mumbai.

Kudos to the efforts of every single person associated with the school to make this dream possible

- Shraddha Malpekar

All I do is win win win!!!



"Sports is life: you win, you lose but the most important thing is the process in which you dissolve."

Sports Day, an event generally held once a year in all schools, not only teaches us that physical fitness is not only the key to a healthy body, but it is the basis of dynamic and creative intellectual activity. We at Gopal Sharma International School organised an exciting Sports Day 2025-26 at the Naval Ground, Kanjurmarg. 19th December, 2025 was the big day wherein the playground was overflowing with zeal, passion and excitement. We at GSIS, encourage our students with the greed to win, which gives them the energy to keep competing.

Dr Sunny Mathew, Principal GSIS escorted our chief guest Mr Deepak Londhe, a national medalist in Triple jump with a 15 years professional career to declare the Sports meet open. The Chief guest not only addressed the gathering but also created an awareness amongst the crowd as to why fitness is important. He was extremely delighted to see a huge number of students participating in all possible track events.

The students displayed a wide array of energetic and bouncy Sports events. A well-co-ordinated March past was a feast to the eyes of the ones sitting there. The highlight of the day was the Band Display. Students with their colourful Neon costumes grabbed the show with their Zumba and the Calisthenic Lezim moves. The proud parents could be seen filled with happiness to see their children competing for the Inter house competitions; that is palpable. The Chief guest and our Principal awarded the trophies, certificates and medals to the winners of various sports events.



The day not only brought in cheer but also filled the air with oodles of Power, Self confidence and offcourse Winning Spirit. The event was a grand success. Kudos to the entire team of GSIS.

- Shraddha Malpekar

HKM Mumbai in Powai: nurturing hearts, homes and harmony through timeless wisdom & divine kirtans

In today's fast-paced urban life, Powai stands as a vibrant blend of professionals, families, students, and senior citizens. While the area is known for its energy and modern outlook, there is also a growing need for inner balance, meaningful connections, and value-based living. Responding to this need, **HKM Mumbai (Hare Krishna Movement Mumbai)** has been actively conducting a variety of spiritual and cultural programs in and around Powai, aiming to enrich lives with timeless wisdom from the Bhagavad Gita and India's spiritual heritage.

Sunday Gita Life Sessions at Gopal Sharma School, Powai

One of the most impactful initiatives of HKM Mumbai in Powai is the **weekly Sunday Gita Life sessions held at Gopal Sharma School from 5 pm- 7 pm.** These sessions attract people from diverse age groups and backgrounds—working professionals, homemakers, senior citizens, and young seekers.

Rather than being academic or preachy, these sessions present the **Bhagavad Gita in a highly practical and relatable manner**, addressing real-life challenges such as stress, relationships, purpose, decision-making, and emotional resilience. Each session combines interactive discussions, thought-provoking reflections, and simple takeaways that participants can immediately apply in their daily lives. Over time, many attendees have shared how these sessions have helped them become calmer, more focused, and more value-oriented.

Mantra meditation, Aarati, Sankirtan and delicious dinner prasadam adds further to these programs.

Home Kirtan Programs: Bringing Spirituality Home

HKM Mumbai also conducts **home kirtan programs** across Powai and nearby areas. These programs bring families and friends together in a warm, joyful atmosphere filled with soulful chanting, short discussions, and shared prasadam (sanctified food).

In an age where families often struggle to spend quality time together, home kirtans create a space for **bonding, positivity, and collective spiritual experience.** Many residents have found that such programs help create peace within the home, strengthen relationships, and introduce children to spiritual values in a natural and joyful way.

ICVK Programs: Values for Young Minds

Understanding the importance of value education for the younger generation, HKM Mumbai conducts **ICVK (Indian Culture and Values for Kids)** programs. These sessions are specially designed for children and teenagers, helping them learn essential values like respect, gratitude, self-discipline, compassion, and confidence through stories, activities, and interactive learning.

Parents in Powai have appreciated how these programs provide children with a strong moral foundation, helping them navigate peer pressure and modern challenges while staying rooted in Indian culture.

Bhagavad Gita Study Circles and Discussion Groups

In addition to large gatherings, HKM Mumbai facilitates **Bhagavad Gita study circles and discussion-based sessions** for those who wish to explore the scriptures more deeply. These smaller groups allow participants to ask questions, reflect, and grow steadily in understanding and application of spiritual principles.

Such forums help people see the Gita not as a religious text limited to a particular group, but as a **universal guidebook for life**, relevant to anyone seeking clarity and balance.

Why These Activities Matter Today?

The growing participation in HKM Mumbai's programs in Powai reflects a deeper truth: **people are seeking meaning beyond routine success.** Stress, loneliness, anxiety, and a sense of emptiness are common even in well-developed localities. The activities conducted by HKM Mumbai aim to address these concerns by nurturing inner strength, positive habits, and a sense of community.

These programs are open to all—regardless of age, background, or prior spiritual exposure—and focus on personal transformation rather than conversion.

An Invitation to the People of Powai

HKM Mumbai warmly invites residents of **Powai and nearby locations** to experience these programs and see the difference for themselves. Whether one is seeking peace of mind, value-based guidance for children, meaningful community interaction, or a deeper understanding of life, these initiatives offer something valuable for everyone.

By coming together, learning together, and growing together, we can make Powai not only a great place to live—but also a place to **live with purpose, harmony, and heart.**

For more details or to get involved:

- Contact: 8976608350
- Website: www.hkmmumbai.org



Following the call: ADHD, social media and the search for balance



Debika Chaudhuri

Folktales often carry a quiet warning. Many of them speak of enchanted sounds drifting through forests at dusk, a drum that beats on its own, a flute that seems to call your name, or a glowing path that promises wonder if only you follow it a little further. In these stories, villagers, especially the young, are warned not to chase the sound endlessly. Those who do often lose track of time, miss their way home, or return changed, disconnected from the rhythm of everyday life.

Today, that enchanted call has taken a new form. It lives in our pockets and glows on our screens. For youngsters and increasingly for adults the endless scroll of reels, shorts, and notifications mirrors that mythical call from the forest. Each swipe promises something exciting, funny, or validating, but like the folktale's drumbeat, it rarely tells us when to stop.

This parallel becomes especially important when we talk about Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD) a condition often misunderstood as a "youth problem," when in reality it affects families, workplaces, and entire social structures.

In the folktales, distraction is external and mystical. The forest or spirit does not force anyone; it tempts. The choice to follow is human. Similarly, social media does not compel us physically, but its fast visuals, unpredictable rewards, and instant feedback is engineered to hold attention.

The similarity lies in how attention is captured. Both the folktale and the feed exploit curiosity and emotional response. The brain naturally seeks stimulation and novelty, this pull becomes even stronger. Reels offer constant small bursts of dopamine, making sustained focus on activities like reading, conversation, or reflection feel unusually difficult.

The difference, is in the scale and permanence. The enchanted forest existed outside daily life, one could return home and be free. Social media has no such boundary. It follows us into bedrooms, classrooms, dinner tables, and even moments meant for rest.

ADHD today is often framed as something children "have," while adults "deal with" them. This framing in not completely accurate. ADHD impacts parents too, in large numbers. Parents scrolling through phones while children talk, families sitting together but mentally elsewhere, conversations broken by alerts, these are symptoms of the social media competing relentlessly for our focus.

Precious time once spent sharing stories, meals, and silences is quietly eroded. Like villagers who stop gathering at the hearth because the forest calls louder, we are present but not fully there.



Image courtey: Liza Shoenfeld

To dismiss social media entirely would be as unrealistic as banning forests in folktales. These platforms offer genuine positives:

- ADHD individuals often find community, validation, and coping strategies online.
- Creative expression thrives in short-form content.
- Parents learn, connect, and feel less alone.

Yet the negatives are real. Shortened attention spans, heightened restlessness, emotional imbalance, and reduced tolerance for boredom are becoming widespread. For the brains, this can intensify impulse and difficulty with sustained effort. It creates ADHD-like behaviors in daily life. Most importantly, it reduces shared attention which is the foundation of relationships.

Social media is here to stay, just as forests were always part of village life. The wisdom of folktales was never about avoidance, but balance.

Moving forward means:

- Designing screen boundaries, not bans
- Teaching children and adults how attention works
- Valuing boredom as a skill, not a flaw
- Creating tech-free rituals: meals, conversations, bedtime

In the folktales, those who learned when to turn back from the forest lived well. Today, learning when to put the phone down may be our modern version of that wisdom.

The enchanted call will always exist. What matters is whether we still remember the way home to each other.

(The author, Debika Chaudhuri, runs Elzix Foundation, an Educational Consultancy for the past twelve years. She has studied across three continents and has close to three decades of experience as an Executive Educator and Career Coach. She and her team help young people make important choices at critical junctures of their lives; develop self-confidence, if they don't know what to do; help develop their skills to make the right fit; create life-changing educational experiences and help them with college admissions. She may be reached at debikac@elzixfoundation.com)

The man who defended the tides: mangroves, marshes, and Mumbai



Chaarvi Athawale

As part of the Pearls of Powai series, we recognise individuals whose work has shaped environments, institutions, and public thinking over time. Debi Goenka is one such individual. An environmentalist with decades of sustained advocacy behind him, his journey reflects the power of long-term commitment in protecting landscapes that are often taken for granted.



Goenka's connection with nature began early. As a child, he was drawn to mangroves, ecosystems that many overlooked or misunderstood. This interest took flight during his college years in the 1970s, when time spent hiking and exploring the outdoors evolved into purposeful involvement. Upon volunteering with the World Wildlife Fund (WWF) and the Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS), his engagement with environmental work deepened.

What struck him during those years was a contradiction that still feels familiar today. People enjoyed being in nature, but rarely felt responsible for protecting it. Picnics ended, waste remained, and forests were treated as backdrops rather than living systems. That gap between appreciation and accountability would come to define Goenka's environmental journey.

At the time, mangroves were widely regarded as wastelands, areas seen as unproductive and suitable for reclamation. They were cleared for dumping grounds, industries, and infrastructure. Goenka understood, however, that mangroves were among the most productive ecosystems on the planet. They stabilise coastlines, absorb pollutants and heavy metals, store carbon efficiently, reduce the impact of cyclones and tsunamis, and provide critical breeding grounds for marine life that supports coastal livelihoods.

A turning point came in 1983 during a government site visit in Alibaug, where officials were identifying land for industrial development. When large stretches of mangroves were dismissed as wasteland, a young Goenka spoke up, challenging the proposal in front of senior officials. The site was eventually dropped, marking an early but significant success.

Recognising that advocacy needed legal backing, Goenka turned to policy and law. His efforts contributed to mangroves being included under the Maharashtra Felling of Trees Act, an act that prevented mangroves from being cut. Subsequent campaigns helped protect extensive coastal stretches and eventually led to the Coastal Regulation Zone Notification of 1991. This landmark regulation protected India's entire coastline and classified mangroves as ecologically sensitive areas. The CRZ notification was the result of sustained advocacy carried out in a pre-digital era, relying on letters, meetings, and public engagement. The scale of public response played a crucial role.



In 2005, following a Bombay High Court order, Maharashtra established a dedicated Mangrove Cell within the forest department, strengthening institutional mechanisms for protection.

That same year, Goenka founded Conservation Action Trust, a non-profit organisation focused on forests, wildlife, and biodiversity. The Trust works to provide technical knowledge, legal support, and resources to those confronting environmental challenges, with particular emphasis on the role of forests in safeguarding India's water security.

Over the decades, Goenka has been closely involved in protecting Borivali National Park, preventing the denotification of Melghat Tiger Sanctuary, securing large forest tracts in Vidarbha, and supporting the notification of several wildlife sanctuaries and ecologically sensitive areas.

When discussing urban growth, Goenka consistently emphasises the need to respect ecological limits. Development that ignores carrying capacity, he believes, ultimately reduces quality of life rather than improving it. This perspective is increasingly relevant in rapidly urbanising neighbourhoods, especially Powai.

Despite his many achievements, Goenka is clear that environmental responsibility does not rest with institutions alone. The environment belongs to everyone, and its protection requires collective action. His work stands as a reminder that lasting change is built over time, through persistence, informed engagement, and the willingness to speak up when it matters most.

In Mumbai, where green spaces are disappearing faster than we notice, Goenka's work is a reminder that protecting the environment is not just an option anymore, it's essential. Clean air, safe water, resilient coastlines, parks where kids can actually run, have slowly transformed into abstract ideals rather than basics of living. His journey shows that even in a city of millions, a few determined people can tip the balance. Nature does not send reminders, and the clock isn't pausing, so neither should we.

Ragi and the calcium story the world learned too late

Calcium tablets may seem like a recent triumph of global nutrition science. Throughout the twentieth century, researchers in Europe and North America identified widespread deficiencies and responded with supplements that delivered minerals in precise doses. These tablets became everyday items, viewed as reliable shortcuts to stronger bones and better health.

Yet centuries before this scientific movement began, India had already mastered the challenge of calcium intake through a grain so small that its importance was often overlooked. That grain was ragi.

Ragi, or finger millet, is one of the oldest cultivated crops in the subcontinent. It grew in dry regions, supported farming communities, and quietly provided one of the richest natural sources of calcium among plants. Long before the world invented packaged supplements, Indian households consumed a food that not only delivered high levels of calcium but did so in a form the body could absorb smoothly. The strength of ragi comes from its internal structure. Its minerals are woven into a network of natural fibers, essential amino acids, and complex carbohydrates. This slows digestion and allows the body to process calcium gradually. Many modern tablets release nutrients faster than the body can use them. Ragi works differently. It supports absorption in a steady flow, matching the body's own pace.

Along with calcium, ragi carries antioxidants, plant proteins, and compounds that support tissue repair and stable energy. It is a naturally balanced food. While the world eventually turned to supplements to correct nutritional gaps created by industrial diets, India had already been eating a grain that met these needs through everyday meals.

Traditional recipes reflect this long-standing wisdom. Ragi porridge for children, ragi laddoos for new mothers, and ragi bhakris for farmers were part of daily life across regions. These dishes were not based on scientific charts. They were based on lived experience. People saw the results in stronger bones, better stamina, and more consistent health across generations.

Over time, polished rice and refined wheat replaced ragi in many urban kitchens. As diets shifted, supplements rose to fill the gaps that natural foods once covered. Yet today, with renewed attention on whole grains and ancestral foods, ragi has returned to the spotlight. Scientific studies now confirm what traditional knowledge understood intuitively. Ragi contains far more calcium than most cereals, supports digestion, and offers a nutrient profile that modern diets often lack.

Reviving ragi is not just about nostalgia. It is about recognising that certain foods already solved nutritional problems long before laboratories attempted to replicate their effects. Ragi stands as evidence that India possessed a deep, practical understanding of nutrition well before calcium tablets became global staples. Before supplements existed, there was ragi. And as India reconsiders what healthy eating truly means, this ancient grain is ready to serve once again.



- Anushka Bahorey
Grade 11,
Singapore International School (Mumbai)

Christmas celebrated with warmth and togetherness at Panch Smruti

Panch Smruti residents came together to celebrate Christmas in a warm and cheerful atmosphere, embracing the true spirit of the season. The premises were beautifully decorated, creating a festive setting that brought the community together.



Residents of all age groups participated in the celebration, enjoying moments of bonding, joy, and reflection. The event highlighted the values of unity, inclusiveness, and goodwill, reinforcing the strong sense of community at Panch Smruti.

The celebration concluded on a joyful note, leaving behind smiles, shared memories, and festive cheer.

Powai: a village hidden inside a city



Girija Menon

There was a time when Powai was a picnic spot. School trips, bus rides that felt impossibly long, laughter began even before we reached the destination. The lake, the trails, the trees, the sense of stepping into a jungle of sorts. For children, everything felt larger than life. The ride itself felt like a journey, the air lighter, innocence riding along with us. Innocence comes is shades so many and those memories come back to pat one on the shoulder as age catches up. School picnics are certainly one of them.

Years later, Powai returned to my life in a very different way. This time as an adult, a mother to a teenager, stepping into what felt like a second innings. A new space which I can call home, a change of schools for the lad in the house, careers recalibrating themselves. Setting down roots was easier than expected. Friends helped. The conveniences at Hiranandani Gardens helped even more. It was a community where starting from scratch didn't feel scary.

Months turned into years. Years quietly stacked themselves into decades. And before I knew it, over twenty-five years had passed. Careers today

Yet, step outside this polished patch and wander towards the IIT markets and the by lanes beyond, and something remarkable reveals itself. Not much has changed.

Old buildings still stand their ground. Fish vendors occupy the same corners they probably have for decades. Vegetable and fruit sellers lay out their wares with practiced ease. The weekly market still appears, selling everything from kitchen tools to odds and ends for those who like a bargain or simply enjoy the joy of finding one at a fraction of the cost outside. Some new shops have come up, yes, but the older ones remain. Steady. Familiar. Unmoved by time.

This part of Powai is still a village. Urbane, yes, but unmistakably a village.

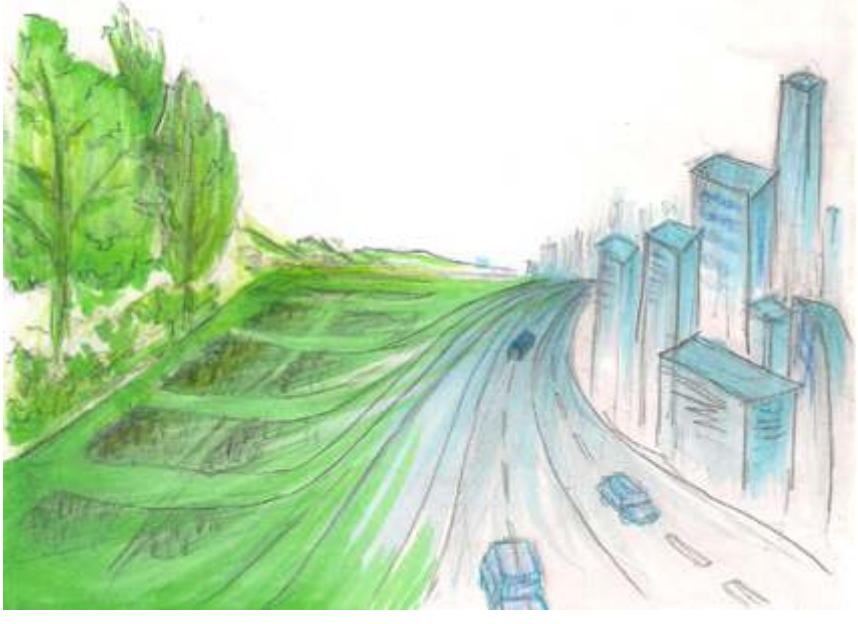
Faces are familiar. Smiles are exchanged on the roadside. If you disappear for a while, someone notices. When you return, you are welcomed back without questions. There is a sense of recognition that quietly reassures you that you belong. Not because you bought something expensive from them or live in a certain building, but simply because you are part of the everyday rhythm of that space.

This coexistence feels uniquely Indian. Where the urbane and the rustic don't compete, but thrive side by side. Where connections between customers and vendors stretch across decades. Where relationships aren't transactional, but remembered.

Having travelled abroad often, I know how rare this is. Elsewhere, connection ends at a polite "good morning" or "have a nice day" at the billing counter. Courteous, efficient, and distant. Two worlds. Two very different ways of living.

Here, in Powai, I live in both. A village heart within an urbane setup. The best of both worlds, really. And when I pause to think about it, I realise how gratitude often comes not from grand things, but from these small, familiar moments that quietly stay with you.

Powai lets me live two lives at once — the comfort of an urbane address and the quiet warmth of a village like setup that still knows my face — and that, to me, is a rare kind of richness.





(Girija Menon, the author, enjoys her passion for writing. Her first love is poetry; an astute observer of the world around us, she loves writing down her thoughts in both poems and prose. LIFE THREADS is what she uses to weave this one-of-a-kind fabric that spans reams. She can be reached at – whisperingverses@gmail.com)

Authentic self-care
Resolution or Relief?



Palak Sardana

Open dialogues awareness around mental health, popularity of holistic living & emphasis on preventive care especially post pandemic has put the spotlight on self-care like never before.

Contemporary self-care is often presented as a set of soothing practices—rest, relaxation, leisure and techniques for lifestyle optimization. Markets are flooded with plethora of aids to assist these goals. Yet a quiet contradiction remains; though people are practicing more self-care than ever (the self-care Industry is projected to double up-to USD 1 trillion by 2030), yet discontentment, burn-out, anxiety & depression looms at an all-time high.

From local hand-made soap and skin care manufacturers to big corporates and hospitals, everyone is vying to get the customers hooked on to their wellness products and programs. Right from high-tech health care gadgets tracking fitness metrics, to apps marketing meditation and wellness solutions, self-care options are rife and rampant. Spas, fitness classes, wellness retreats are all being marketed as ultimate solutions to achieving wellness. But is that really true? What is their efficacy?

US based Psychiatrist & best-selling author Pooja Lakshmin calls these solutions "faux self-care" as they offer temporary relief but not lasting well-being.

External fixes do not address the real issues that lead to exhaustion. Candles, crystals, salt baths, massages, and motivational speeches are, at best, indulgent comforts that fail to address the deeper sources of distress.

The biggest challenge is that the marketing-driven narratives increasingly present these superficial practices as self-care, fostering a misunderstanding that distances people from examining and addressing root causes. Relief or pleasure is not equivalent to resolving the underlying condition.

Across centuries, psychology, philosophy, and spirituality have examined forms of well-being that endure beyond hedonic pleasure. These traditions remain marginal in the modern self-care industry because they resist commodification & require self-awareness and sustained personal effort.

Self-care is not about comfort or indulgence; it is about clarity and self-understanding. Awareness of our values, capacity to discern & healthy boundaries, helps us live concretely which enhances the quality of life, manifold. Support from a therapist or a health coach can be beneficial in this journey of self-discovery. There are no fake promises of quick turnarounds as the process involves commitment, effort and awareness that gradually leads to an inner alignment. Rest and pleasure aren't forbidden but they must not be used as a substitute or diversion for inner imbalance.



In his essay, 'The wisdom of life', German philosopher Arthur Schopenhauer launches a realistic & psychologically penetrating inquiry into how one might suffer less in a world where lasting happiness & well-being is impossible. He concludes that cultivating ones inner world in terms of character, intellectual pursuits, clarity & temperament influences happiness & well-being more that material possessions or fame. He emphasises that external circumstances can only modify life to a limited extent. A person with a restless, anxious, or envious disposition would suffer even in favourable conditions, while someone with inner calm and intellectual richness may remain relatively content even in modest circumstances.

He doesn't romanticise life either to be a bed of roses or a floor of thorns but proposes navigating life with prudence to avoid pain and suffering by proactively going for what serves this life better. He discards personal possessions (beyond basic comforts) & pursuit or attainment of fame to be the cause of personal well-being or happiness. On the contrary, he asserts that they are the major causes for distress and dissatisfaction in life. He argues that endless striving—wanting more comfort, success, or happiness—is counter-productive as it creates its own exhaustion. Desire renews itself faster than it can be satisfied. In this light, constant self-optimization can actually increase burnout.

His observations are as relevant as they were more than a century ago as we are witnessing a burn-out like never before in all rapidly growing economies which might be prosperous wealth wise, but rank nowhere high on happiness or wellness index.

However, the ultimate perspective on self-care comes from Sāṁkhya Darśana, one of India's most insightful philosophical traditions'. It systematically examines material remedies for human suffering—from medicinal substances and gemstones to ritual practices—and concludes that none can offer permanent relief. Its central insight is that a solution cannot be final if it belongs to the same order of reality as the problem. Sāṁkhya locates the root of suffering in misidentification, asserting that no external or internal manipulation of conditions can resolve it fully. Liberation arises through discernment (viveka-khyāti), when consciousness (Puruṣa) recognizes its distinction from the mind, body construct of Prakṛti.

Examination of these perspectives makes it clear that authentic self-care cannot come from plain consumption. It is based on the foundation of discernment. And that can only be cultivated. Why not dedicate this year to some self-work.

Happy reflections in the new year!

(Palak Sardana is a Harvard certified wellness coach, a mental health counsellor, yoga teacher & founder of wellness venture, Tranquility Unlimited. Via these articles, her endeavour is to present non-invasive & practical models of wellness grounded in ancient wisdom and modern scientific research. She runs ongoing wellness classes. For joining or booking a personalized consultation/session, write to tranquilityunlimited@gmail.com)

The new year plate reset - a guide to rebalance and rethink your plate



Nisha Singh

Another year has gone by. The new year brings with it a clean slate and opportunities to rethink one's approach amongst many other things to think about one's health. In fact, New Year's resolutions are a notorious trap. Made with zest and abandoned with ease. In such a scenario I would like to remind you of my favourite word - Balance. Between all the chaos and chatter of over-information, from trending diets, Instagram reels, conflicting advice from "well - meaning experts", the idea of a balanced diet may feel both consuming as well as intimidating.

In reality, balancing your meal plate is actually not so complicated.

A balanced plate doesn't mean giving up on comfort foods like dal - chawal nor does it mean including expensive superfoods which are not local. And it definitely does not mean strict meal plans. On the other hand, most of the traditional Indian foods and food combinations are naturally balanced not only in terms of calories but also nutrients.

Let's begin with understanding what a balanced meal plate really means.

From a nutrition perspective, a balanced meal provides:

- Carbohydrates for energy, the body's fuel of choice.
- Protein for muscle repair, immunity, and satiety like a maintenance crew.
- Healthy fats for hormones, brain health, and vitamin absorption, ensuring that the body functions smoothly.
- Fibre, vitamins, and minerals for digestion, gut health, and overall wellness, providing protection and support.

Miss one too often, and something starts to feel off—fatigue, cravings, poor digestion, low immunity. Not immediately dramatic, just subtly uncomfortable. No single food does all of this. Balance comes from combining foods, not eliminating them. And no single "superfood" does the job.

In this context vegetables and fruits play an important and indispensable role. Half the plate must be filled with vegetables and fruits. In a day roughly about 400 grams of vegetables and 100 grams of fruits must be included. Vegetables are the unsung heroes of health. Vegetables supply fibre that keeps digestion regular and blood sugar steady. They feed gut bacteria that influence immunity, inflammation, and even mood. They deliver vitamins and minerals that the body cannot manufacture on its own. Do not restrict it to a couple of spoons of vegetables or a little salad like an afterthought. Instead make it the main ingredient of your plate. All local and seasonal vegetables like lauki, tori, cauliflower, peas, fenugreek leaves, bittergourd, etc work. Aim for variety more than quantity. Different colours mean different nutrients.

Carbohydrates have unfortunately gained a bad reputation over the years. They often get blamed for weight gain, but they are your body's primary energy source, especially for the brain. The key is quality and portion, not elimination. Throughout the day, include roughly about 250 grams of carbs from a variety of sources. When eaten alone, they get digested very quickly and cause repeated hunger pangs. But when paired with protein, fat and fiber, their energy release is gradual and hence supports the body in performing its most basic daily functions with ease. Roti, rice, millets, poha, daliya—these foods have sustained generations. Removing them entirely often creates more problems than it solves, including fatigue, irritability, and rebound overeating. Balance doesn't demand elimination. It asks for moderation and pairing.



In the context of the Indian diet, protein is often the missing piece. And even if included it's underconsumed. Include about 250 to 400 grams, split between pulses, milk and milk products and egg and meat products. Without enough protein, meals fail to satisfy. Hunger returns too soon. Muscle strength declines with age. Immunity takes longer to recover. Protein doesn't need to be excessive to be effective—it just needs to be consistent. Dal, beans, curd, paneer, eggs, fish, chicken, soy, tofu—all count. What matters is that protein is present at most meals, not saved for special occasions or fitness phases. When protein becomes a regular part of the plate, energy steadies, cravings subside, and eating becomes less chaotic.

Don't forget healthy fats. They are not the enemy. In fact, they help absorb vitamins (A, D, E, K), support brain health, and keep joints lubricated. About 30 grams of a variety of fats can be included in the diet. Problems arise not from fat itself, but from excess and poor-quality sources. Used mindfully, traditional fats—ghee, mustard oil, groundnut oil, coconut oil—support health rather than sabotage it. Nuts and seeds add both nourishment and satiety when included in small amounts. A balanced plate doesn't avoid fat, rather included it in the right quantity.

Lastly, a balanced plate doesn't work in isolation. Studies show that how you eat matters even more than what you eat. And therefore, lifestyle habits become a key. Rushed meals, irregular timings, poor sleep, and chronic stress all interfere with digestion and metabolic health. In such conditions even the best planned diets will fail. Simple habits amplify the benefits of balanced meals. Eat at regular times and be mindful of the food plate in front of you. Chew properly and slowly. Eat without distractions. Ensure there is regular physical activity. Maintain sleep hygiene. These habits ensure that you don't confuse hunger signals, or hamper digestion by eating mindlessly. Activity improves digestion as well as insulin sensitivity. Good sleep keeps cravings away.

Small, repetitive behaviours matter far more than short bursts of intensity. A balanced plate is not a diet. It's your groundwork. Your foundation. One that works quietly and repeatedly. Always remember along with balance, consistency is important.

This year, instead of chasing the "perfect" diet, aim for a balanced one. Your body will thank you—quietly, steadily, and for the long run.

You can follow Dietitian Nisha on Instagram for nutrition & fitness tips and live interactive sessions at – nurtiwellness.by.dt.nishas

We at My Powai are taking our readers' queries related to Diet & Nutrition, which Ms. Nisha Singh will reply to in our forthcoming issues.

You can send your questions at: dietnutrition.queries@gmail.com

(The writer is a gold medalist in Food & Nutrition with more than 12 years experience. She manages various ailments through lifestyle and dietary modifications and specializes in weight loss & management. She practices at 102, Crystal Center, Raheja Vihar, Powai or Smile Craft, 23, Annapurna Industrial estate, Opp. CCD, Ghatkopar East. For appointments: 022 2857 6537 Email: singhnisha@gmail.com)

Andhra food: honest, fiery and unforgettable



Sherry Bhatnagar

From Singapore, we got posted to Visakhapatnam. What we expected to be a change of address turned into a quiet awakening of the palate. Andhra cuisine didn't ease us in—it made itself known through bold heat, assertive sourness, and flavours rooted deeply in place. Here, food is direct and purposeful. Chillies lead without apology, tamarind sharpens every note, rice anchors the meal, and oils add depth rather than excess. From comforting everyday Pappu to robust, celebratory curries, each dish reflects a cuisine that values clarity over compromise.In Visakhapatnam, we discovered that Andhra food isn't about spectacle—it's about strength, balance, and an honesty that lingers long after the meal is over. Before we talk about Guntur chillies, the heart of Andhra cuisine, let us first prepare the much-needed sweet dish—Bobbatlu. Soft, ghee-kissed and delicately sweet, Bobbatlu is Andhra's way of setting balance before the spice takes over. Made with a thin, tender dough wrapped around a jaggery–chana dal filling, it is a festive classic that brings warmth, comfort, and quiet indulgence to the table.



Bobbatlu (Andhra Style)
Ingredients
- Chana dal – 1 cup
- Jaggery (grated) – 1 cup
- Cardamom powder – ½ tsp

Outer dough
- Maida – 1 cup
- Turmeric – a pinch
- Salt – a pinch
- Oil – 2 tbsp
- Water – as needed

Method
1. Cook chana dal till soft; drain well and mash smooth.
2. Cook dal with jaggery till thick; add cardamom. Cool. This is called Poornam
3. Knead maida with salt, turmeric, oil, and water into a soft dough; rest 1–2 hrs.
4. Stuff dough with poornam, roll gently, cook on tawa on medium heat with ghee till golden.

Serve hot with extra ghee.

Next is Kodi Kura is Andhra cuisine at its boldest—no tomatoes, no coconut, just slow-cooked onions, freshly ground spices, tamarind, and the unmistakable heat of Guntur chillies, meant to be eaten hot with rice and ghee.



Rayalaseema Chicken Curry (Kodi Kura) – Authentic & Fiery
Ingredients
- Chicken (with bone) – 750 g
- Onions (sliced) – 2 large
- Ginger-garlic paste – 2 tbsp
- Guntur red chilli powder – 2–3 tsp
- Coriander powder – 2 tsp
- Turmeric – ½ tsp
- Tamarind pulp – 1½ tbsp
- Curry leaves – 1 sprig
- Salt – to taste
- Groundnut oil – 4 tbsp

Roast & Grind
- Dry red chillies – 5–6
- Coriander seeds – 2 tbsp
- Cumin seeds – 1 tsp
- Garlic cloves – 6–8

Method
1. Dry-roast spices; grind coarse.
2. Heat oil, sauté onions till dark golden; add curry leaves.
3. Add ginger-garlic paste, then chicken; fry till sealed.
4. Add turmeric, chilli powder, ground masala, salt; cook till oil separates.
5. Add tamarind pulp + little water; simmer till thick and spicy. Thick gravy, bold heat—true Rayalaseema style.

Serve hot with rice and ghee.



And now time to share my all-time favourite—Upma Pesarattu (Stuffed). Crisp moong dal dosa, soft spiced upma inside, endlessly comforting and perfect any time of day. Paired with ginger chutney or allam pachadi, it's humble food with enduring appeal.

Upma Pesarattu
Ingredients
Pesarattu batter
- Whole green moong – 1 cup (soaked 6 hrs)
- Ginger – 1 inch
- Green chillies – 2
- Cumin – 1 tsp
- Salt – to taste

Upma filling
- Rava (sooji) – ½ cup
- Onion (finely chopped) – 1 small
- Green chilli – 1
- Mustard seeds – ½ tsp
- Curry leaves – few
- Oil – 1 tbsp
- Salt – to taste
- Water – 1 cup

Method
1. Grind soaked moong with ginger, chillies, cumin, salt into thick batter.
2. Cook upma: heat oil, splutter mustard, add onion, chilli, curry leaves; add water, salt, rava; cook thick.
3. Spread batter on hot tawa, place upma in centre, fold dosa, cook till crisp with oil.

Serve hot with ginger or peanut chutney.

(Sherry Bhatnagar is a passionate food storyteller with deep roots in Indian regional cuisine, the author writes where memory, migration, and the kitchen intersect. Having lived across cultures yet firmly anchored in Indian flavours, her work explores food not just as nourishment, but as identity, tradition, and lived experience—told with honesty, restraint, and quiet depth.)

January 2026



Richa Pathak

January doesn't rush you; it resets you. This is the month where intentions quietly take root, confidence rebuilds, and life asks a gentle but powerful question: What are you ready to do differently this year?

Aries (Mar 21 – Apr 19)
The year opens with renewed fire and clearer direction. You feel ready to act, but wisdom now guides your speed. Professional matters improve when you lead with strategy rather than urgency, while relationships benefit from calmer conversations. **Lucky Color:** Fresh Red **Lucky Day:** Tuesday **Remedy:** Place a copper coin in your wallet to keep energy focused and decisions steady.

Taurus (Apr 20 – May 20)
January invites you to build comfort without stagnation. Financial planning becomes smarter, and emotional security grows through honest self-reflection. You may choose quality over quantity in all areas of life. **Lucky Color:** Soft Olive **Lucky Day:** Friday **Remedy:** Light a ghee lamp near a plant at home to strengthen grounding and growth energy.

Gemini (May 21 – Jun 20)
New ideas arrive like fresh air. Conversations spark inspiration, and your confidence in expressing thoughts increases. The key is to simplify—one clear intention will outperform many scattered ones. **Lucky Color:** Lemon Cream **Lucky Day:** Wednesday **Remedy:** Write one intention for the year on paper and place it under your pillow for three nights.

Cancer (Jun 21 – Jul 22)
The new year wraps you in emotional reassurance. Family bonds deepen, and you feel safer releasing old fears. Financial habits improve when you trust consistency over emotion-based decisions. **Lucky Color:** Pearl White **Lucky Day:** Monday **Remedy:** Keep a moonstone or silver object near your bedside to maintain emotional balance.

Leo (Jul 23 – Aug 22)
January gently returns your spotlight—not through noise, but through presence. Your confidence feels natural, and others respond positively to your warmth. Creative and leadership roles grow when ego steps aside. **Lucky Color:** Warm Gold **Lucky Day:** Sunday **Remedy:** Offer water to the Sun at sunrise once a week to renew confidence and clarity.

Virgo (Aug 23 – Sep 22)
The year begins with clean slates and calmer thoughts. You focus on healthier routines, smarter planning, and emotional simplicity. Let go of self-judgment—progress begins where pressure ends. **Lucky Color:** Mist Green **Lucky Day:** Thursday **Remedy:** Organize your workspace and place a small crystal or glass object for mental clarity.



Libra (Sep 23 – Oct 22)
January teaches you the art of choosing yourself. Relationships grow stronger when honesty replaces adjustment. Career discussions move in your favour when you trust your voice. **Lucky Color:** Rose Peach **Lucky Day:** Friday **Remedy:** Keep fresh flowers or petals in a bowl of water at home to restore emotional harmony.

Scorpio (Oct 23 – Nov 21)
A quiet strength defines your new year opening. You feel lighter after releasing emotional weight, and financial decisions become sharper. This is a month of inner authority, not control. **Lucky Color:** Deep Plum **Lucky Day:** Tuesday **Remedy:** Write one old habit you wish to release and safely discard it on a new-moon day.

Sagittarius (Nov 22 – Dec 21)
January reawakens your sense of purpose. Travel plans, learning, or future visions excite you again. Keep optimism grounded with small daily actions—this is how dreams begin to move. **Lucky Color:** Horizon Blue **Lucky Day:** Thursday **Remedy:** Place a yellow item near your study or desk to attract growth and opportunity.

Capricorn (Dec 22 – Jan 19)
Your birthday season aligns you with authority and renewal. Career matters feel structured, and your discipline sets a powerful tone for the year ahead. Just remember—rest is also a form of productivity. **Lucky Color**: Stone Grey **Lucky Day:** Saturday **Remedy:** Write three intentions for the year every Saturday of January and keep them in your diary.

Aquarius (Jan 20 – Feb 18)
The year begins with innovation and emotional detachment from old limits. New connections inspire growth, and your originality finds the right audience. Health improves with mindful rest. **Lucky Color:** Electric Teal **Lucky Day:** Wednesday **Remedy:** Keep a bowl of clean water in the north zone of your home to invite fresh thinking.

Pisces (Feb 19 – Mar 20)
January opens the door to intuition, creativity, and spiritual comfort. You feel more aligned with your inner rhythm. Financial clarity comes when emotions stay balanced. **Lucky Color:** Sea Foam **Lucky Day:** Friday **Remedy:** Apply a drop of rosewater on your wrists before sleep for emotional peace and clarity.

(Astrologer Richa Pathak masters the art of Astrology, Vastu & Numerology. In-person consultation with prior appointment can be done at 207, Lantana, Nahar Amrit Shakti, Chandivali, Powai. She also gives Virtual Consultation & can be reached @ 8452920640 & www.jyotishdham.com)